Joey Pigza Swallowed the Key

By Jack Gantos

JOEY: **(Pg 3-4)** At school they say I'm wired bad, or wired mad, or wired sad, or wired glad, depending on my mood and what teacher has ended up with me. But there is no doubt about it, I'm ***wired***. One day, we were doing math drills in class and every time Mrs. Maxy asked a question, like "What's 9 times 9?" I'd raise my hand because I'm really quick at math. But each time she called on me, even though I knew the answer, I'd just blurt out, "Can I get back to you on that?" Then I'd nearly fall out of my chair laughing. *(laughing heartily)* Can I get back to you on that? "Out in the hall," she said. And the class cracked up.

INTRODUCTION

Meet Joey, a bright, good-hearted boy who struggles with ADHD. Joey knows he's different—he has trouble focusing, sitting still, and making good choices, even when he wants to and his wild behavior often leads to trouble at school. But at home, things are no easier: his grandmother is manipulative and abusive, and his mother, though trying her best, has a history of drinking and instability – But he'll get back to you on that . . .

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JOEY: **(Pg 7-9)** My dad ran off when I was in kindergarten and my mom went after him. My grandmother raised me until this past summer. That's when my mom finally turned around and remembered me. One morning she rang the doorbell. I wasn't sure she was my mom because I didn't even remember what she looked like.

I was a wired-up mess by the time Mom came back. By then everyone thought my grandma was the nutty old lady responsible for my bad behavior. But I am how I am because Grandma was born wired, and my dad, Carter Pigza, was born wired, and I followed right behind them. It's as if our family tree looks like a set of high-voltage wires strung across a field from one steel tower to the next.

GRANDMA: Joey, I want you to pull your act together. You don't want to turn out like your father, do you?

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JOEY: **(Pg 10-11)** People who blame Grandma for my behavior are unfair to think that she was the crazy one and I was innocent. It was more that we were whacked-out partners. I'd be the Hulk and she'd be Doctor Doom and when the phone rang, we'd run at it screaming and yelling and slam into each other, and by the time one of us got the upper hand the person on the other end had hung up. (beat) Sometimes she could be funny. But not often. Most times she'd just get mad . . .

GRANDMA: Don't touch. Don't wiggle. Don't run. Don't yell!

JOEY: **(Pg 12)** After Mom came back Grandma got worse. She got meaner and she began to scare me. **(Pg 15)** She'd say the same thing over and over again:

GRANDMA: **(Pg 14)** You don't know what you're doing. You're ruining everything. You never listen to me. I always said you were as dumb as dirt!

JOEY: **(Pg 12-13)** About a month before school started she got so mad at me she threw everything out of the refrigerator, yanked out the shelves and flung them across the floor.

GRANDMA: Now get inside and stay inside! I said get in or I'll tell your mom!

JOEY: But I wouldn't get in. I knew there were good rules and bad rules, and having a time-out inside a refrigerator was a bad rule.

She should have been on meds. Big-time Grandma-sized meds. People just called her a batty old bird. But she was sick like me, only old, so her sickness was different. *(thinking, then softly)* **(Pg 3)** Can I get back to you on that? *(shakes it off and gets lost in the story again)*

[Transition: Oh, yeah . . . So anyway, it was out in the hallway at school . . .] **(Pg 4-5)** I stood in the hall for about a second until I remembered something I wanted to try. I had seen the Tasmanian Devil on TV whirling around like a top so I unbuckled my belt and pulled on the end really hard, as if I was trying to start a lawn mower. Before long I was bouncing off the lockers because I was dizzy too. I got going really fast and began to snort and grunt like the Tasmanian Devil *(snorting and grunting)* until Mrs. Maxy came out and clamped her hands on my shoulders. She stopped me so fast I spun right out of my shoes! **(Pg 6)** And we had a little talk about my behavior goals

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MRS. MAXY: **(Pg 25)** Joey, there are limits in the classroom. And if you can't live by the class rules then we'll have to send you down to the special-ed class for extra help. We've talked to your mom about this.

JOEY: Okay *(to audience)* only saying the word because agreeing to stuff was the best way to make it stop. *(to Mrs. Maxy)* Okay. Okay! *(takes some deep breaths to calm down)* **(Pg 28)** *[Transition: When I got home, Mom said]* now let's get you some medicine. She put a pill in my hand and a glass of water in the other, but before I could take the pill, she got the bottle of Amaretto.

MOM: *(pouring it into a glass)* See, Mommy has her own meds.*(raises the bottle to Joey)* It comes in a bottle.

JOEY: We clinked glasses and I took my pill. I could feel it going down my throat like a little white round superhero pill on its way to beat up all the bad stuff in me. Everyone said it would help. And it did. I felt like a normal kid for a while. But then my old self started to sneak up. *(shakes head in bewilderment, long beat)*

(Pg 30) I was sitting at my desk after lunch and Mrs. Maxy was writing a long list of spelling words. I was playing with the house key that was on a long string around my neck. **(Pg 31)** I was trying to train myself to swallow the key so I could slowly pull it back up from inside my belly, like I was fishing. It hurt because sometimes the key got caught sideways, but I just gave the string a tug and straightened it out. Since I was doing it after lunch, bits and pieces of food would stick to the key and around the string and I'd suck them off.

(Pg 32-33) Suddenly Mrs. Maxy swooped down on me. She yanked the string out of my mouth, took her sharp "teacher only" pointy scissors and cut the string and put the key in my T-shirt pocket.

MRS. MAXY: Keep your mind on your work.

JOEY: **(Pg 3)** Can I get back to you on that? *(beat)* So . . . my mind wandered and before long I didn't remember about the string missing and I plucked the key out of my pocket and popped it into my mouth. *(showing the key on his tongue and whispering to another student)* What'll you give me if I swallow this?

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(not waiting for an answer) I worked up my saliva and swallowed hard . . . I did it! *(opens mouth to show it's empty)* Then I reached to pull the string . . . *(panics when he can't find it, he screams)* Mrs. Maxy, I ate my key! *(takes some deep breaths to calm down)*

(Pg 69) I was one of the ***special*** people. My mom said I was special, the nurse said I was special, and I was also in special ed. **(Pg 73)** Even though I'm difficult I'm very special and smart. **(Pg 76)** *(shouting)* Math drills are one of my strengths!

[Transition: Another day at school I stayed in at recess to] **(Pg 72)** make a million bumper stickers that say 'Hate Is Not a Family Value.' My mom saw one and said she wished she had a million to put on every car in the world. **(Pg 73-75)** I got the safety scissors and began to cut the poster board into bumpersticker-sized strips. But [it] was too thick and the scissors kept twisting. The bell rang, so when Mrs. Maxy got up from her desk to stand in the hall, I snuck up to her desk and grabbed her secret extra-sharp teacher scissors. I was racing back with scissors in my hand when it happened. I tripped and sort of dove through the air with the open scissors in front of me like some evil Big Bird's beak when Maria walked sideways across my path. *(look of shock and horror)*

I thought I was the one who was screaming. But it wasn't me. *(getting excited)* You should have seen the blood. It was like a pipe had burst. And she stood there shaking with her eyes wide open like she stuck her finger in the electric socket. I bent over and picked up the tip of her nose, which looked like a tiny piece of sliced banana. Then I stood up and pressed it back in place, but the blood sprayed out like a shower nozzle. *(panics again, shrieking)* I'm sorry! I'm sorry!

I tried to wrestle the scissors from Mrs. Maxy who had taken them from me because I wanted to cut my whole nose off to show just how sorry I was. But Mrs. Maxy wouldn't let me have the scissors and she kept shouting, "Time out! Time out! Go to your corner!" But I was so nuts I couldn't tell you the difference between a corner and a circle or a square. It was bad, and everyone was staring at me like I was a maniac killer. *(begins to cry)*

******Meeting with Mom and the Principal*******

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PRINCIPAL: Because he has injured another student, he has to be suspended and receive mandatory counseling. That is school policy. The district special-ed bus will pick him up. Given Joey's record, he was bound to end up at the center anyway. Maybe this is a blessing in disguise. What happens now is all up to him. . .

JOEY: *(crying)* **(Pg 3)** Can I get back to you on that? **(Pg 90)** *(long beat as he composes himself)* I'm Joey Pigza. **(Pg 51-52)** I can have good days. *(proudly)* Entire days when I wake up and I'm calm inside like water when it's not boiling. I just get dressed and eat breakfast, thinking about what I'd like to do with my day. And then the most amazing thing -- after I think about what I want to do, like read, or see a friend, or write a poem, I actually do all that stuff. *(incredulously)* I ***think*** it, then I ***do*** it. This is **not** how I usually operate. *(rate of speech picking up quickly)* Usually I wake up with springs popping inside my head, shoot out of bed and directly to the kitchen where I ricochet around after food, zing up the hall to the bathroom where I try to brush my teeth, but I brush mostly my lips and chin and then I explode across the living room and carom off the furniture until Mom gets a grip on me and wipes the toothpaste off my face and works a pill down my throat. From Ricochet Rabbit to Charlie Brown in no time flat. *(long beat)*

I love it when the meds work, and when I go to school and stay in my seat and kids don't call me Zippy and teachers pat me on the head and give me gold stars and say nice things to me. *(beat) (gathering up his courage)* **(Pg 73)** Even though I'm difficult I'm very special and smart. **(Pg 76)** *(he does a little dance and yells)* Math drills are one of my strengths!

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SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

2003 National Qualifier
2006 National Qualifier
2009 National Qualifier
2016 National Qualifier - MS
CO State Qualifier